

Prompt Engineering Meta and COSTAR

Two ways to get world-class results from AI — Meta Prompting and COSTAR.

1

Meta Prompting

Let the AI write the prompt for you — when you're not sure how to structure the request.

2

COSTAR

A six-part checklist for a complete, precise prompt — when you know how to structure the request.

What is prompt engineering?

Structuring your instructions so an AI gives you the best possible output. Think of it like giving directions.

VAGUE DIRECTIONS

“Go somewhere nice.”

You end up lost — the AI picks a destination, and usually not yours.

PRECISE DIRECTIONS

“Take me to Times Square NYC using the fastest route.”

You arrive exactly where you intended to go.

TODAY'S USE CASES · (1) Draft a job description for hiring an AI Engineer (2) Write a rejection email to a candidate

Detail is what the AI runs on

1

Treat it as a new hire

Brilliant and fast — but it only knows what's in the brief. It cannot see the context in your head.

2

It will never push back

Under-brief it and it still answers — confidently — just not with the answer you actually wanted.

3

Detail in, quality out

More detail in your prompt means a more targeted output. You teach the AI what “good” looks like.

More detail in = better, more targeted output. Every time.

Meta prompting — let the AI write the prompt

Meta prompting is asking the AI to write the prompt for you.

Instead of struggling to structure a complex request, you tell the AI your goal — and let it be your prompt engineer.

1 You bring the goal

You know the outcome you want — a memo, a plan, an analysis.

2 The AI brings the craft

It knows what works: context, tone, format, constraints. It drafts the prompt.

3 The burden shifts

Hard part — structuring the request — moves from you to the AI.

When you're unsure how to structure it — start with your goal, and let the AI build the perfect prompt.

Meta prompting in four steps



You stay in charge of the goal. The AI does the prompt engineering.

The meta-prompt — paste it whenever you're stuck

Task: [Draft a job description for hiring an AI Engineer — responsibilities, must-have skills, and why our team is a great place to work]

“Act as an expert Prompt Engineer. Please write the best possible prompt that I can use to get a world-class response from you. Include any necessary context, role-playing personas, or constraints that will make the output high-quality.”

This exact prompt is how today's deck and handouts were built. One template, world-class results.

COSTAR — the six parts of a complete prompt

C Context

Background that helps the AI understand your situation and constraints.

O Objective

The specific goal or outcome you want the AI to achieve.

S Style

The writing style — formal, casual, technical, creative, journalistic.

T Tone

The emotional register — encouraging, authoritative, empathetic, direct.

A Audience

Who will read or use the output — experts, beginners, executives, customers.

R Response

The output format — paragraph, bullet list, table, email, code block.

Fill all six and the AI knows not just **what** to do, but **how**, for **whom**, and in what **format**.

COSTAR in action — a rejection email

THE TASK

Turn a hard, human task into a prompt the AI can nail —

Write a rejection email to a strong candidate — without burning the relationship.

FILL IN ALL SIX COSTAR PARTS

- C** Rejecting a high-potential candidate over cultural-fit concerns.
- O** Write a rejection email that preserves the relationship.
- S** Professional, warm, conversational.
- T** Empathetic, encouraging, honest.
- A** A talented engineer with 10 years of experience.
- R** Email format, 3–4 paragraphs, 150–200 words.

Miss even one part and the output drifts generic. All six, and the AI has the full picture.

The same task. Two very different emails.

VAGUE PROMPT

"Write a rejection email to a candidate."

WHAT THE AI RETURNS

"We have decided to move forward with other candidates. Thank you for your interest."

Cold, generic, forgettable.

COSTAR PROMPT

"Context: rejecting a talented engineer who fit our skills but not our pace. Objective: preserve the relationship... Style: warm. Tone: empathetic. Audience: a senior engineer. Response: email, 3–4 paragraphs."

WHAT THE AI RETURNS

"Your technical skills are genuinely impressive... This wasn't about your qualifications — it's about cultural fit... We'd love to stay connected."

Warm, specific, relationship intact.

Same model, same task. Specificity is what unlocks quality.

Which should you use?

IF ...

Unsure how to structure it?

Use Meta Prompting

Your goal is clear, the structure isn't. Let the AI craft the prompt.

IF ...

Know how to structure the request?

Use COSTAR

You can structure the request yourself — across all six dimensions.

IF ...

Complex and multi-step?

Use both

Meta-prompt to break it down, then COSTAR to execute each piece.

Neither is universally better — choose by your situation.

Three rules to take back to your teams

1

Verify what matters

A great prompt improves quality — it does not guarantee truth. AI can state wrong facts with full confidence. Check anything before it leaves your hands.

2

Protect the data

Never paste confidential, customer, or personal data into AI tools that aren't company-approved. When in doubt, leave it out.

3

You stay accountable

The AI drafts; you decide. Judgment, sign-off, and responsibility always remain with the human.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

Not sure how to structure it? Meta-prompt it. Know how to structure it? Run COSTAR.

THIS WEEK

1 Pick one task

Choose something you write or analyze often.

2 Meta-prompt it if you're stuck

Let the AI draft the prompt from your goal.

3 Refine it with COSTAR

Tune all six parts — then save the prompt to reuse.

Templates and examples: the one-page summary + Prompt Engineering - Meta and COSTAR - Examples.md